Philippines' president refused permission for further US air operations to be flown from Clark; this effectively ended US fighter support over the South China Sea.

The Battle of Bashi Channel

The next day, September 16, the aircraft carrier *Liaoning*, which was approximately 175 nm northwest of the Babuyan Islands, just north of Luzon, launched a combination of J-31 and J-15 jets to try to intimidate the *Gerald Ford*, which was to the southeast of Okinawa, approximately 75 nm northeast of the Philippines' Batanes, in the western Pacific Ocean. The geography of eastern Asia's inner seas meant that the most direct route to intercept the American ships would have forced the Chinese to transit past the Japanese-held Ryukyu Islands, making them vulnerable to land-based jets from Okinawa as well as potential antiship missiles launched from islands along the chain. The PLAN vessels instead swung south through the Taiwan Strait, running the risk of encountering lurking US submarines, and then northeast to the Bashi Channel. Nonetheless, the Chinese planes were decisively defeated by a combination of the *Gerald Ford*'s F-35s and F-22s launched from Kadena, on Okinawa, effectively preventing the *Liaoning* and its flotilla from moving forward. However, one Type 055D PLAN destroyer, its newest variant, escorting the *Liaoning* used its HQ-9 SAMs to destroy one F-35 and one F-22, underscoring the danger to US fighters. At the same time, the US escort ships also halted just within visual range of East Sea Fleet vessels on the horizon.

At this point, the clashes threatened to involve land-based forces, which would have escalated the war to a higher, and possibly uncontrollable, level. US Pacific Fleet anticipated the employment of DF-21D antiship ballistic missiles against the *Gerald Ford*, and indeed two missiles were launched from Chinese territory approximately four hours after the aerial engagement. The Americans countered with antimissile SM-6s to knock down the DF-21Ds, which failed; however, both Chinese missiles also missed the *Gerald Ford*. Some in Washington